3.2 A New Party System

When something isn't working, you probably want to change it—out with the old, in with the new. It often works that way in politics, too.

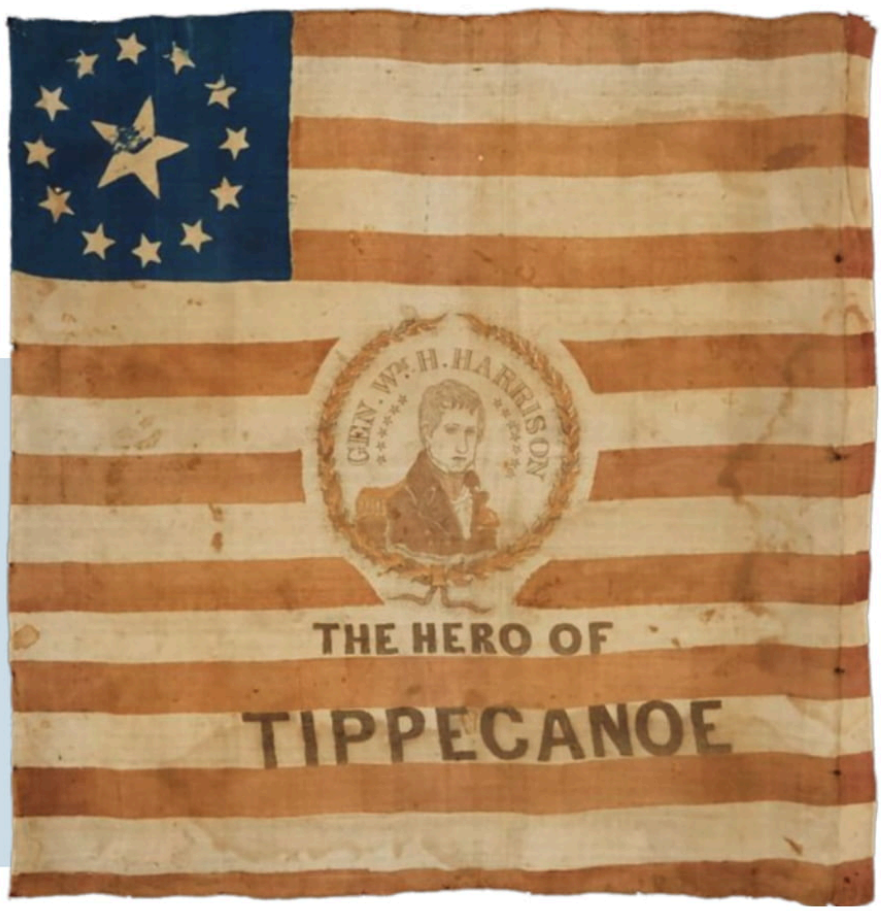
MAIN IDEA A new political party formed to oppose Jackson, and its candidate won the 1840 presidential election.

A CHANGE OF PARTIES

The old way of doing things definitely wasn't working in the United States in the late 1830s. While the economy slumped, the depression dragged on. Most of the factories in the East had let their workers go and closed down. Many of the unemployed in the cities went hungry and lived on the streets.

President Martin Van Buren didn't believe that government should interfere with the economy. But Jackson's old opponent, Senator Henry Clay, disagreed. He and Senator Daniel Webster claimed the government should step in and help fix the economic situation. Clay wanted the government to impose tariffs that would raise the price of imports and encourage Americans to buy domestically produced goods. He believed the federal government should fund infrastructure development by building a network of roads, canals, and railroads. Clay also called for the establishment of a new national bank. His economic program was called the American System.

In 1834, senators Clay and Webster had formed a new political party, which they called the **Whig Party** after a British political group that had criticized the monarchy. Clay, Webster, and other opponents of Andrew Jackson chose the name because they believed Jackson had exceeded his powers as president. In fact, they often referred to him as "King Andrew." Unlike the Democrats, who supported an agrarian society, the Whigs promoted business and the expansion of industry.



Harrison Campaign Flag
Throughout the 1840 presidential campaign, the Whigs made much of William Henry Harrison's war experience 28 years earlier at the Battle of Tippecanoe, where he won a victory over the Shawnee. The party created this banner, combining a picture of Harrison with the American flag and a label underscoring his heroism at Tippecanoe.

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THE ELECTION OF 1840

As the 1840 presidential election approached, the Whigs believed they had a good chance of winning it. Many Americans blamed the country's economic woes on Van Buren and seemed ready for a change. The Whigs nominated William Henry Harrison of Ohio as their candidate for president and **John Tyler** of Virginia as his running mate.

Harrison was a national figure because he had led U.S. Army troops against the Shawnee at the Battle of Tippecanoe in 1811. He'd also been a hero during the War of 1812. Making the most of Harrison's war experience, the Whigs came up with the catchy slogan "Tippecanoe and Tyler too."

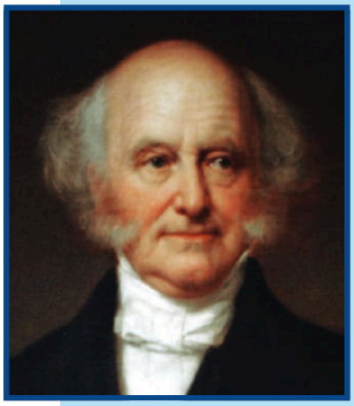
Because Harrison lived on a farm, he also gained the reputation as a "common man" of the frontier. As a matter of fact, he came from a wealthy family. But that didn't stop the Whigs from including pictures of a rustic log cabin in banners and Harrison's campaign pamphlets. They also held parades, sang songs, and had their candidate go out on the campaign trail himself. Harrison was the first presidential candidate to do so.

Harrison narrowly defeated Van Buren in the 1840 election, but just 32 days after taking office, he died. He had delivered a long inaugural address—the longest on record—without wearing a hat or overcoat on a cold March day and came down with pneumonia.

Tyler took Harrison's place after his death but received little support from his party. Tyler's views were actually more in line with those of the Democrats. The Whigs had chosen him to attract southern voters. In time, they expelled him from the party and took to calling him "His Accidency." In spite of their differences, Tyler worked well with the mostly Whig Congress. During his single term in office, Tyler focused on strengthening the country by expanding and opening up the West.

DID YOU KNOW?

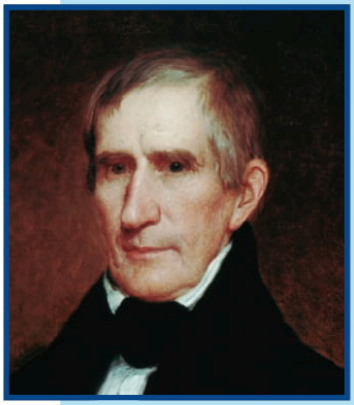
There is something unique and unusual about each of the presidents you have read about in this lesson.



Martin Van Buren

Eighth president

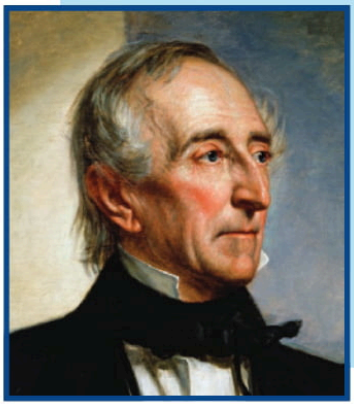
- First president to be born a U.S. citizen rather than a British subject
- Nicknamed "Old Kinderhook" for his hometown, Kinderhook, New York. The expression "OK" (or *okay*) came into use during his presidency.



William Henry Harrison

Ninth president

- President for only 32 days
- First president to die in office
- Attended medical school to become a doctor, but he could not afford the tuition after his father died. He dropped out and joined the military.



John Tyler

Became tenth president when William Henry Harrison died in office

- Only former U.S. president to side with the Confederacy in the Civil War
- Father of 14 children who lived into adulthood

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why were the Whigs in a good position to win the 1840 election?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did the agrarians' and the industrialists' views on the economy differ?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why did the Whigs use pictures of a log cabin in Harrison's campaign?

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